

Rare or Literary Structures

C2 · Renan the Teacher — English Language Academy

1. BRIEF EXPLANATION

These structures are rare in everyday speech but appear in formal writing, legal/religious language, literature, and set expressions. Recognizing and occasionally using them signals command of the language's outer edges.

- a) Advanced (formal/archaic) subjunctive — the bare base form of the verb (no -s, no "would/should") used after certain verbs/adjectives expressing necessity, demand, or recommendation, especially in formal American English and fixed expressions.

The committee demanded that he resign immediately. (not "resigns")

It is essential that every member be present.

Fixed expressions: So be it. Suffice it to say. Be that as it may. Come what may. God save the Queen.

- b) Emphatic "do" in literary contexts — "do/does/did" + bare infinitive used not to form a question or negative, but to add emphasis or formality, common in literary and rhetorical prose.

She did say she would come, but she never showed up. (emphasizing that she really did say it)

Little did I know, this decision did shape the rest of my life.

- c) Inverted conditionals with an omitted auxiliary — an extremely formal/literary variant where "if" is dropped, the auxiliary is inverted, and sometimes an entire clause is compressed with ellipsis.

Had I but known, I would have acted differently. ("but" here is an archaic intensifier meaning "only")

Were it not for your generosity, this project would never have existed.

Be it ever so humble, there's no place like home. (archaic subjunctive + inversion, fixed literary expression)

These forms are not required for everyday fluency, but recognizing them is essential for reading literature, historical texts, legal documents, and formal ceremonial language — and using one occasionally in writing adds a deliberate note of gravity or formality.

2. EXAMPLES

- 1. The judge ruled that the defendant be released on bail.

- 2. It is imperative that the report be submitted by Friday.
- 3. Be that as it may, the decision has already been made.
- 4. Suffice it to say, the meeting did not go well.
- 5. She did warn us, but nobody listened.
- 6. Little did we know, the storm did far more damage than expected.
- 7. Had I but known the risks, I would never have agreed.
- 8. Were it not for her intervention, the deal would have collapsed entirely.
- 9. Come what may, the team will finish what it started.
- 10. The board recommended that the policy be reviewed annually.

3. COMMON MISTAKES

- 1. Incorrect: The committee demanded that he resigns immediately.

Correct: The committee demanded that he resign immediately.

Why: The formal subjunctive after "demand that" uses the bare base form, not the third-person -s form.

- 2. Incorrect: It is essential that every member is present.

Correct: It is essential that every member be present.

Why: After "it is essential/imperative/vital that," use the subjunctive "be," not "is."

- 3. Incorrect: She did said she would come.

Correct: She did say she would come.

Why: Emphatic "do/did" is followed by the bare infinitive, not the past tense form — the tense is carried by "did."

- 4. Incorrect: Had I but know, I would have acted differently.

Correct: Had I but known, I would have acted differently.

Why: This inverted structure needs the past participle after "had," matching normal past perfect formation.

- 5. Incorrect: Were not it for her help, we would have failed.

Correct: Were it not for her help, we would have failed.

Why: Word order in this fixed inversion is "Were it not for," not "Were not it for."

4. EXERCISES

- A. Gap-fill (use the correct subjunctive, emphatic "do," or inverted conditional form)
- 1. It is essential that everyone ____ (be) informed before the vote.
- 2. The board insisted that the CEO ____ (step) down.
- 3. She ____ (do/warn) us, but we didn't take it seriously.
- 4. ____ (had/I/know) the truth sooner, I would have acted differently.

- 5. ____ (be/it) not for his quick thinking, the situation would have been far worse.
- 6. It is vital that the evidence ____ (be) reviewed carefully.
- 7. Suffice ____ (it/say), the plan failed spectacularly.
- 8. He ____ (do/try) to warn them, though few believed him at the time.
- B. Rewrite / Transformation (rewrite each sentence using the literary/formal structure indicated)
- 1. It's necessary that the manager approves the request. (correct to formal subjunctive)
- 2. She really did tell them the truth, even if no one believed her. (keep the emphatic "did," rewrite cleanly)
- 3. If I had known that earlier, I would have changed my plans. (rewrite using "Had I but known...")
- 4. If it weren't for your support, this company wouldn't exist. (rewrite using "Were it not for...")
- 5. The court ordered that the company pays a fine. (correct to formal subjunctive)
- C. Error Correction
- 1. It is essential that the report is finalized today.
- 2. The judge demanded that the witness tells the truth.
- 3. She did said she would help us.
- 4. Had I but know, I would have warned you.
- 5. Were not it for his generosity, the charity would have closed.
- 6. Suffice to it say, the results were disappointing.
- D. Guided Production
- 1. Write one sentence using the formal subjunctive after "It is essential/vital/imperative that..."
- 2. Write one sentence using emphatic "do/did" for literary emphasis.
- 3. Write one sentence using "Had I but known..." about a past regret.
- 4. Write one sentence using "Were it not for..." to describe something or someone that made a difference in your life.

5. ANSWER KEY

- A. Gap-fill
- 1. be
- 2. step
- 3. did warn
- 4. Had I known
- 5. Were it
- 6. be
- 7. it to say
- 8. did try
- B. Rewrite / Transformation
- 1. It's necessary that the manager approve the request.
- 2. She did tell them the truth, even if no one believed her.
- 3. Had I but known that earlier, I would have changed my plans.
- 4. Were it not for your support, this company wouldn't exist.
- 5. The court ordered that the company pay a fine.
- C. Error Correction
- 1. It is essential that the report be finalized today.
- 2. The judge demanded that the witness tell the truth.
- 3. She did say she would help us.

- 4. Had I but known, I would have warned you.
- 5. Were it not for his generosity, the charity would have closed.
- 6. Suffice it to say, the results were disappointing.
- D. Guided Production (sample answers)
- 1. It is imperative that the entire team be present for tomorrow's briefing.
- 2. He did try to stop them, though his warning came far too late.
- 3. Had I but known how demanding the course would be, I might have thought twice before enrolling.
- 4. Were it not for my grandmother's encouragement, I never would have pursued music.

Renan the Teacher — English Language Academy ·
renangrossi.github.io/englishclasses